

TRIBAL ANTHROPOLOGY - COMPREHENSIVE NOTES

Part 1: Occupational & Linguistic Classifications

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SECTION 1: OCCUPATIONAL (ECONOMIC) CLASSIFICATIONS

Key Concept: Tribal economic life ranges from gathering to settled agriculture. Each tribe has a distinctive economy but also practises subsidiary occupations.

MIND MAP - Six Economic Types

Type	Key Feature	Example Tribes
1. Hunting & Gathering	Oldest economy; foraging from nature	Chenchu, Yanadi, Onge, Jarawa, Kadar
2. Pastoralism	Domestication of animals; semi-nomadic	Toda, Gujjar, Bhotia
3. Shifting Cultivation	Slash-and-burn on hill slopes (Jhum)	Gonds, Baiga, Kukis, Maler
4. Settled Agriculture	Plough-based permanent cultivation	Santhals, Mundas, Oraons, Gonds
5. Tribal Artisans	Handicrafts as subsidiary occupation	Asur, Agaria, Bhils, Nagas
6. Industrial Labour	Wage labour due to land loss	Santhals, Oraons

1. HUNTING AND GATHERING

Definition: Foraging = searching for food in nature (fruits, nuts, animals, fish) by gathering, fishing, or hunting. Oldest economic system since Homo sapiens.

Global Context: Food gatherers = 0.004% of world population. In India: mainly south India and Andaman Islands.

Key Features

Feature	Detail
Technology	Simple - digging stick, basket, bows, arrows, spears
Settlement	Nomadic / Semi-nomadic
Population	Low density; bands of 25-30 people
Labour Division	Men hunt; Women collect food
Surplus	No surplus, no trade

Feature	Detail
Unit	Small, self-sufficient band

SCHOLAR - Marshall Sahlins: Called hunter-gatherers the "ORIGINAL AFFLUENT SOCIETY" - affluence defined not by material wealth but by satisfaction through balance with nature.

Sustainability Features:

- Limited extraction + seasonal rotation of resource zones
- Ritual taboos on hunting during breeding seasons
- Collective ownership and sharing norms prevent hoarding
- Deep ecological knowledge through oral traditions, songs, myths

CASE STUDIES - Hunting & Gathering Tribes

(a) CHENCHU (Andhra Pradesh)

- Location: Nallamala Hills of AP and Telangana
- Economy: Forest foods, honey, roots, small game
- Follow seasonal foraging cycles based on rainfall
- Customs: Hunting restrictions during breeding; collective sharing of meat and honey
- Deep ecological knowledge of flora and fauna

(b) YANADI (AP, Tamil Nadu)

- Location: Nellore, Chittoor - near lakes and estuaries
- Skilled fisherfolk and crab catchers
- Tools: Bamboo traps, hand-woven nets
- Men fish and hunt; Women gather fruits, roots, medicinal herbs
- Remarkable knowledge of tides, fish migration, wetland ecology

(c) ONGE (Little Andaman)

- Negrito tribe - hunting, gathering, fishing
- Diet: Fish, turtle, pig, honey, yams
- Egalitarian sharing norms prevent accumulation
- Ritual restrictions: No hunting pregnant animals, no overharvesting yams

(d) JARAWA (Andaman Islands)

- Coastal and forest belt hunter-gatherers
- Diet: Wild pigs, fish, honey, tubers, fruits
- Excellent bow-hunting and navigation skills
- Custom: Group sharing + ritual purification before hunting

(e) KADAR (Kerala)

- Location: Anamalai and Nelliampathy hills
- Skilled honey, wax, and forest produce collectors
- Known for knowledge of elephant trails and herbs
- Acted as forest guides and elephant catchers
- Now combine foraging with seasonal wage work (adaptation)

Fishing as Subsistence: Likely developed parallel to hunting. Groups use nets, traps, harpoons, canoes. Examples: Yanadi near Pulicat Lake, Onge along coastal reefs.

2. PASTORALISM

Definition: Transitional phase between food collection and food production. Subsistence through

domestication of animals. Found in areas not suitable for agriculture.

Key Features

Feature	Detail
Population	Small; move for grazing
Main Activity	Domestication of animals
Movement	Semi-nomadism
Transhumance	Part of group moves with herds; others stay home

Examples:

- Todas - rear buffaloes (Nilgiris)
- Gujjar - rear sheep
- Tschembago - rear pigs
- Bhotias - Uttarakhand

MAJOR CASE STUDY: Nilgiri Hills Inter-Tribal Model

Context: Nilgiri Hills (Tamil Nadu) - home to Toda, Kota, Kurumba, Irula, and non-tribal Badaga. Each occupies a specialised ecological and occupational niche.

Inter-Tribal Division of Labour

Group	Role
Toda	Pastoralists - sacred buffalo herding; produce milk, curd, ghee
Kota	Artisans and blacksmiths; pottery, metal tools; ritual musicians
Irula	Hunters and gatherers; snake catching, pest control
Badaga	Agriculturalists; grains and vegetables
Kurumba	Forest collectors and medicine-men; honey, herbs; shamanic healing

Mechanisms of Exchange:

- **Barter:** Toda dairy products traded for Badaga grains/Kota crafts
- **Ritual Ties:** Toda ceremonies require Kota musicians + Kurumba priests
- **Reciprocity:** Mutual obligations, not market pricing

Sacred Dairies: Managed by Toda priests - only ritually pure men may enter. Buffalo milk used in offerings - symbolises link between humans, animals, gods.

Modern Changes:

- Monetisation: Tea plantations, tourism converted barter to cash
- Occupational shifts: Kotas to modern carpentry; Todas supply milk to Aavin cooperatives
- Cultural Revival: NGOs promote Toda embroidery and Kota pottery

Significance: Self-regulating, multi-ethnic economy where each group complements others. Traditional customs ensured resource diversity, reciprocity, and ecological restraint.

3. SHIFTING CULTIVATION

Definition: Agriculture on hill slopes using slash-and-burn. Dates back to Neolithic times (8,000-10,000 years

ago). Transition from nomadic to settled life.

Other Names: Jhum (NE India), Bewar (Baiga), Podu, Kumri

Process:

- 1. Select plot; cut plants and trees
- 2. Dry and burn to ashes
- 3. Till soil with digging stick or hoe
- 4. Sow seeds at onset of monsoon
- 5. Harvest in winter
- 6. Leave plot to fallow; move to new plot

Tribes: Gonds, Baiga, Kukis, Maler

Sustainability Dimensions

Dimension	Key Point
Ecological Balance	Fallow regeneration; soil restoration; mixed cropping
Social Regulation	Community-owned land; collective decisions; prevents conflict
Cultural Integration	Rituals before clearing; post-harvest ceremonies
Gender and Labour	Men clear and burn; Women sow and weed

Challenges: Govt restrictions shorten fallow cycles; monocropping disturbs balance; sedentarisation schemes ignore tribal wisdom.

FAO (2019): Traditional shifting cultivation CAN be sustainable if customary laws and long fallows are maintained.

CASE STUDIES

(a) MALER Tribe (Rajmahal Hills, Jharkhand)

- Also called Paharia
- Small-scale rotational shifting cultivation on forested hill slopes
- Crops: Millets, pulses, maize, cucurbits, roots
- Customs: Ritual offering before cutting; taboos on clearing near springs/sacred groves
- ICAR + ASI: Maler jhum is more ecologically stable than commercial monocropping

(b) BAIGA Tribe (Maikal Hills, MP & Chhattisgarh)

- Practice = Bewar cultivation
- Customary laws enforced by village elders and clan heads
- Taboos: Felling fruit-bearing trees (mahua, mango, tamarind) strictly prohibited
- Sacred groves preserved for ritual and biodiversity
- Ash = natural fertiliser; minimal tillage prevents soil compaction
- **SCHOLAR - L.P. Vidyarthi (1963):** Nature-Man-Spirit Complex - economic activity, ecology, and belief form an INTEGRATED SYSTEM

4. SETTLED AGRICULTURE

Key Features

Feature	Detail
Settlement	Permanent rural and urban

Feature	Detail
Population	Higher density than other types
Technology	Ploughing, irrigation, crop rotation
Labour	Division by age and sex
Land	Private/hereditary ownership
Leadership	Full-time political leaders (headman, councils)

Examples: Santhals, Mundas, Oraons, Gonds, Baiga

CASE STUDIES

(a) SANTHALS (Jharkhand, WB, Odisha, Bihar)

- One of the LARGEST tribal groups in India
- Location: Chotanagpur Plateau
- Settled plough cultivation, mainly rain-fed monsoon agriculture
- Crops: Rice, millets, pulses, maize, oilseeds
- Land: Hereditary and patrilineal ownership
- Labour: Family-based + reciprocal exchange called **Parma**
- Village headman (**Manjhi**) oversees agricultural arrangements
- Festivals: **Sohrai** (cattle, fertility) and **Baha** (agricultural cycle)
- Deity: **Marang Buru** (Great Mountain Spirit)
- **SCHOLAR - N.K. Bose:** Santhal agriculture represents a bridge between subsistence economy and market participation

(b) APATANI Rice-Fish Cultivation (Arunachal Pradesh)

- Location: Ziro Valley, Lower Subansiri District
- High-altitude wetland system surrounded by pine-covered hills
- UNIQUE integrated rice-fish farming - most sophisticated indigenous practice in NE India
- Rice and fish cultivated TOGETHER in same wet field
- Technique: Terraced fields + bamboo irrigation channels + wooden sluices
- Fish: Common carp (*Cyprinus carpio*) introduced after rice transplantation
- Benefits: Fish eat insects/weeds (natural pest control); fish waste adds nutrients (natural fertiliser)
- Community collectively manages irrigation - strong communal institutions
- **Recognition: FAO - Globally Important Agricultural Heritage Systems (GIAHS)**

Santhals vs Apatanis Comparison

Aspect	Santhals	Apatanis
Type	Subsistence to settled plough-based	Advanced integrated rice-fish farming
Innovation	Parma (reciprocal labour)	Rice-fish co-cultivation
Commonality	Both combine traditional ecological knowledge with community cooperation	

5. TRIBAL ARTISANS

Major Crafts

Craft	Tribes
Basket Making (Bamboo)	Bhils, Santhals, Nagas
Tool Making (Iron & Wood)	Agarias, Lohars

Craft	Tribes
Spinning & Weaving	Gonds, Kotas, Apatanis
Pottery	Kumbhars, Santhals

TRIFED: Tribal Cooperative Marketing Development Federation (est. 1987, Ministry of Tribal Affairs). Promotes tribal handicrafts through TRIBES India outlets. Implements Van Dhan Yojana and MSP for MFP.

CASE STUDIES

(a) ASUR Tribe (Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Bihar) - PVTG

- Location: Gumla and Latehar, Jharkhand
- One of the EARLIEST iron-smelting communities in India
- Used primitive bloomery furnace technique
- Small clay furnaces; bellows from animal skin; charcoal fuel
- Produced sickles, ploughshares, knives, arrowheads
- Decline: Industrial steel plants (Tata, Bokaro) + Forest Dept restrictions
- Cultural: Iron is sacred; mythical ancestor Asura Raja; festivals Sarhul and Karma invoke the Iron God
- Today: Mostly agricultural labourers; some continue blacksmithing

(b) AGARIA Tribe (MP, Chhattisgarh, UP, Jharkhand)

- Sub-group of Gonds; traditionally iron smelters
- Name from "agar" = furnace in local dialects
- Location: Sidhi, Shahdol, Mandla (MP); Sonbhadra (UP); Bilaspur (CG)
- Used pit furnaces lined with clay; bamboo bellows; charcoal fuel
- Smelting villages formed INDUSTRIAL CLUSTERS - early division of labour
- Today: Shifted to agriculture, daily labour; some continue via TRIFED/Van Dhan

6. AGRICULTURAL AND INDUSTRIAL LABOURERS

- Many tribes became LANDLESS LABOURERS due to colonial policies and land alienation
- Work on others' land for wages in cash, kind, or crop share
- Examples: Santhals and Oraons lost traditional land, now depend on wage labour
- Seasonal migration to nearby regions for manual/industrial work during lean seasons

SECTION 2: LINGUISTIC CLASSIFICATION OF TRIBES

India has over **700 tribal groups**, each with distinct language/dialect. Four main linguistic families:

Overview Table

Family	Key Tribes	Location	Antiquity
1. Austro-Asiatic (Munda)	Santhali, Mundari, Kharia	Eastern & Central India	One of earliest in South Asia (Anderson, 2008)
2. Tibeto-Chinese (Sino-Tibetan)	Bodo, Naga, Lepcha	Northeast India	Affinities with East/SE Asia
3. Dravidian	Gondi, Kurukh, Kui	Central & South India	At least 4,000 years (Krishnamurti, 2003)

Family	Key Tribes	Location	Antiquity
4. Indo-European	Hajong, Bhili	NE & West India	Contact and assimilation layers

1. AUSTRO-ASIATIC FAMILY

Over 150 languages, 100+ million speakers across Southeast Asia and South Asia.

Scholars on Origin

Scholar	View
W. Schmidt	Named the Munda language as Austro-Asiatic Mongoloid people entered India from NE, brought Munda languages which spread to middle India Austro-Asiatic brought by Kolarians through west end of Himalayas + Mon Khmer speakers from east Certain nouns in Hindi, Punjabi, Bengali are borrowed from Munda languages
Heine Geldern (1928)	
Hutton	
Suniti Kumar Chatterji	

Two Main Branches in India

(a) Mon-Khmer Branch:

- Khasi - primarily Meghalaya
- Nicobari - Nicobar Islands

(b) Munda Branch:

- Santhali, Kherwari, Ho, Mundari, Gondi, Kharia, Savara, Khond, Gadaba
- Santhali = one of the largest - spoken in Jharkhand, WB, Odisha, Bihar

Unique Feature: System of phonetic tones distinguishes it from other families.

2. TIBETO-CHINESE (SINO-TIBETAN) FAMILY

Divided into: Siamese-Chinese and Tibeto-Burman

(a) Siamese-Chinese Sub-family

Tai-Khampti: Major tribe of Arunachal Pradesh; Namsai district; name means "land full of gold"; believers of Theravada (Hinayana) Buddhism

Tai Phake (Phakial): Small tribe of Assam (~2,000); migrated from Thailand in late 18th century

(b) Tibeto-Burman Sub-family - Four Branches

Branch	Languages/Tribes
1. Tibeto-Himalayan	Bhotia (Darjeeling); Chamba, Lahauli, Kanauri
2. Non-Pronominalized Himalayan	Lepcha (Rong); Toto (West Bengal)
3. Arunachal	Aka/Hrusso, Abor, Miri, Dafla

Branch	Languages/Tribes
4. Assam-Burmese	Bodo/Kachari, Garo, Naga, Singpho, Kuki-Chin, Manipuri, Lushai

3. DRAVIDIAN FAMILY

250 million speakers; predominantly southern India.

SCHOLAR - Robert Caldwell (1856): Published "Comparative Grammar of Dravidian Languages" - established Dravidian as a major world language family.

SCHOLAR - Krishnamurti (2003): Dravidian languages trace back at least 4,000 years - predating Indo-Aryan expansion.

Major Dravidian Languages

Language	% Speakers
Telugu	34.5%
Tamil	29.0%
Kannada	15.4%
Malayalam	14.4%
Gondi	1.2%
Brahui	0.9%
Kurukh	0.8%

Dravidian STs: Kurukh (Eastern India) and Gondi (Central India)

Outside India: Brahui (Balochistan, Pakistan); Dhangar (Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh); Tamil (NE Sri Lanka)

4. INDO-EUROPEAN FAMILY

Origin: Proto-Indo-European homeland = Pontic-Caspian Steppe (modern Ukraine, S. Russia, Kazakhstan) around 4000-3000 BCE.

SCHOLAR - Marija Gimbutas: Proposed the KURGAN HYPOTHESIS for PIE homeland.

Expansion: Westward into Europe; Southeast into South Asia (Indo-Iranian branch).

- Indo-Aryan: Sanskrit (Vedic, c.1500 BCE) to Hindi, Bengali, Marathi etc.
- Iranian: Old Persian, Avestan to Persian, Pashto

Tribal Examples

Hajong (Eastern Indo-Aryan): Meghalaya, Assam, Arunachal Pradesh. Indo-Aryan dialect influenced by Tibeto-Burman. Mixed Hindu-animistic practices; festivals Chorkhela and Pusne.

Bhili (Western Indo-Aryan): Bhils of Rajasthan, MP, Gujarat, Maharashtra. Bhili dialects show Dravidian and Munda influences - centuries of contact.

Glottochronology

SCHOLAR - Morris Swadesh (1950s): Proposed Glottochronology - estimates when languages diverged based on rate of loss of shared core vocabulary.

SCHOLAR - Colin Masica (1991): Indo-Aryan languages eventually became the majority tongue of the subcontinent.

ENDANGERED TRIBAL LANGUAGES

Key Data:

- India has 19,500+ languages/dialects
- Second-largest number of endangered languages in world
- UNESCO: 197 endangered + 42 CRITICALLY endangered
- 1961 Census: 1,652 languages; PLSI (2010): only 780 documented
- Only 4% of India's languages represented in Parliament

Critically Endangered Languages

Language	Location	Status
Majhi	Sikkim	Only 4 speakers - one family!
Birhor	Central India	2,000 speakers
Asur	Jharkhand	UNESCO endangered
Korwa	Jharkhand	UNESCO endangered
Koro	Arunachal Pradesh	Endangered
Dimasa	Assam	Endangered

Reasons: Dominance of major regional languages; loss of traditional knowledge; youth migration; loss of intergenerational transmission.

Government Initiatives

Initiative	Detail
CIIL (1969)	Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore
PLSI (2010)	People's Linguistic Survey of India
SPPEL	Protection of languages with less than 10,000 speakers; 117 endangered languages on priority
MLE Programme (Odisha, 2006)	3,385 tribal language teachers; dictionaries for 20 tribal languages
MTBMLE	KISS in Odisha teaches 10 tribal dialects
Community Radios	Asur tribe in Jharkhand uses radio to revitalise language

SCHOLAR - Abbi (2017): Survival of Austro-Asiatic and Tibeto-Burman languages demonstrates deep antiquity and diversity of tribal linguistic heritage.

SCHOLAR - Anderson (2008): Austro-Asiatic (Munda) = one of earliest language families in South Asia.

ALL SCHOLARS - PART 1 QUICK REFERENCE

Scholar	Key Contribution
Marshall Sahlins	"Original Affluent Society" - hunter-gatherers
L.P. Vidyarthi (1963)	Nature-Man-Spirit Complex

Scholar	Key Contribution
N.K. Bose	Santhal agriculture bridges subsistence and market
W. Schmidt	Named Munda language as Austro-Asiatic
Heine Geldern (1928)	Mongoloids brought Munda languages from NE
Hutton	Austro-Asiatic via Kolarians from west Himalayas
Suniti K. Chatterji	Hindi/Bengali nouns borrowed from Munda
Robert Caldwell (1856)	Comparative Grammar of Dravidian Languages
Krishnamurti (2003)	Dravidian = 4,000+ years old
Marija Gimbutas	Kurgan Hypothesis - PIE homeland
Morris Swadesh (1950s)	Glottochronology
Colin Masica (1991)	Indo-Aryan became majority tongue
Abbi (2017)	Deep antiquity of tribal linguistic heritage
Anderson (2008)	Munda = earliest language family in South Asia

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